

On Parents and Children, and On Face to Face

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The sawing-apart teaches us that there are states of unity that are not the proper human relation of "face to face." The face is the turning, the intention toward the encounter, the looking into the face of the other. Turning is an act of the present; it is not ongoing, it is not spread out over time. The face-to-face meeting is present, it is here and now, and in this lies its greatness and its depth — it is the most real being of a life lived in the present. When someone becomes part of our natural environment, when I live with him in one space over time, his presence becomes part of my world, part of the familiar, of the given, of what already exists. The habit of togetherness turns us into a kind of "back to back," which is the state that precedes the sawing-apart. The other exists, but is no longer truly other, is no longer entirely different, he is part of me in the broad sense, part of my world, of the objects and matters that make up the substance of my life. He is with me as part of me, but I do not turn to him — he is "self-evident" to me. The strongest example of this is the family, and parents in particular. Certainly, in the course of growing up and maturing, parents are an inseparable part of me, of my self-definition, of my life, of what surrounds me. I do not stand before them as beings existing in their own right; they always exist in my consciousness as bearing a relation to me — "Mom," "Dad." But this can also occur with a woman I have already lived with for some time, and even with close friends.

This is not a matter of bad relations, but of relations lacking turning, and, in this sense, also lacking a face. The lighting-up of the face creates a renewed relation, a standing opposite; it is a recognition of the one facing me as existing in his own right, and, out of this, as existing in his own right, he is also a wonder to me, ungraspable, like the new. And wonder, cyclically, arouses a lighting-up of the face, curiosity and love. This is a renewal that can occur at any given time. It is aroused by giving thought to the renewal of the relationship. The Zohar teaches us that when my entire other is part of my own "side," in a bond of "back to back," I am, in effect, alone — the verse "It is not good for man to be alone; I will make him a helper against him" deals with the pre-sawing state, in which man is together but without a consciousness of union, in which they are one but not yet "a helper against him."

I feel that there is a repair to be made in our relationship to our parents. Relating to them as "self-evident" does not enable gratitude, and often blocks sensitivity toward them, toward their feelings and their emotions. And indeed, a child need not call his parents by their first names, and he never stands against them out of a relation to them as truly "others" — "a fetus is the thigh of its mother"; ultimately, our flesh is their flesh (per Rashi's interpretation of "and they shall become one flesh" — this refers to the offspring), and in truth we have neither the ability nor the wish to be sawn apart from them entirely. But on the more

significant level, we do indeed disconnect from our parents; we leave them and become independent, establish new family units and identify ourselves with these units. Because of this, we must turn our face to our parents; contrary to what is customary to say, that "our faces are toward the future," it then follows that while the parents' faces are indeed turned toward their children, the children turn their backs to them — we must also turn our faces back, and recognize those from whom we came, those who raised us and labored over us, acknowledge the good and give thanks in return, see their toil, honor them and love them. And although the more essential side is indeed the leaving, and the continuation toward the future, this does not, in any case, contradict the turning-back of the face and the giving of thanks; and in a true standing before the past we receive strength and rootedness that will fill our present and straighten our future. The recognition of the greatness of our parents' giving to us, which can never be repaid "good for good," will hasten us to continue this giving onward, toward the world and toward the future. And in this may everything be blessed.